Kiran Basava
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Research interests: Macroevolution of cognition and sociality, animal culture, integration of fossil data with phylogenetic methods, comparative database construction and transformation of qualitative to quantitative data

Current

April 2024- **Postdoctoral Research Associate,** College of Information Science, University of Arizona
- Building the Animal Culture Database (ACDB), a comparative database of wild animal populations with variables on behavioral traditions and anthropogenic threats
- Collaborating on data science research on biodiversity and evolutionary ecology

Education

2019-2024 **DPhil in Evolutionary Anthropology**, University of Oxford
Thesis: "The cultural evolution of warfare practices: examining the roles of social structure, political complexity, and resource ecology with cross-cultural comparative analyses"

2017-2018 **MSc in Human Evolution and Behaviour** (with Distinction), University College London
Dissertation: "Eschatological beliefs and intergroup conflict: a phylogenetic case study of Islam"

2011-2015 **Bachelor of Arts in Global Studies**, University of California, Los Angeles

Previous positions

2021-2024 **Research Assistant - Postdoctoral Research Officer**, **Diverse Intelligences Project: A Theory for Cephalopod Intelligence**, London School of Economics, U.K.

2017-2020 **Research Assistant**, **Seshat: Global History Databank**, University of Oxford, U.K.

Publications

Basava, K., Bendixen, T., Leonhard, A., George, N. L., Vanhersecke, Z., Omotosho, J., Mather, J., & Muthukrishna, M. (2026). *iScience*. Ecological not social factors explain brain size in cephalopods. https://doi.org/10.1016/j.isci.2026.116324.
**Media: New Scientist (June 21, 2026) 'Octopuses prompt rethink of why animals evolve big brains' by Chris Simms*

Basava, K. (2025). Social complexity is not strongly predictive of indiscriminate killing of wartime enemies in a cross-cultural sample. *Evolutionary Human Sciences*. https://doi.org/10.1017/ehs.2025.10033.

Alam, M., Basava, K. Martinet, K., Román-Palacios, C.,...Van Boxel, D. (2025). Machine Learning in Biological Research: Key algorithms, applications, and future directions. *BMC Biology.* https://doi.org/10.1186/s12915-025-02424-3

Basava, K. & Román-Palacios, C. (2025). A Web App for the Animal Culture Database and a Template for Deploying Comparative Trait Databases With Shiny. *Ecology and Evolution*. https://doi/10.1002/ece3.71913.

Basava, K., Alam, M., Roberts, L., Martinet, K.,...& Román-Palacios, C. (2025). Mapping nonhuman cultures with the Animal Culture Database. *Nature Scientific Data.** https://doi.org/10.1038/s41597-025-05315-y.
**Media: University of Arizona News (June 24, 2025) 'Creature culture: What animal behavior can teach us about saving nature' by Logan Burtch-Buus; Discover Magazine, Year in Science (December 8, 2025) 'Cultured Creatures' by Richard Pallardy*

Basava, K., Bendixen, T., Leonhard, A., George, N. L., Vanhersecke, Z., Omotosho, J., Mather, J., & Muthukrishna, M. (2024). A phylogeny of extant coleoid cephalopods with brain data. *bioRxiv*. https://doi.org/10.1101/2024.04.29.591691.

Basava, K., François, P,. & Whitehouse, H. (2023). The Benefits and Challenges of Linked Datasets for Cliodynamics and Comparative Anthropology. *Cliodynamics: The Journal of Quantitative History and Cultural Evolution*. https://doi.org/10.21237/C7clio14162506.

Basava, K., Zhang, H., & Mace, R. (2021). A phylogenetic analysis of revolution and afterlife beliefs. *Nature Human Behaviour*. https://doi.org/10.1038/s41562-020-01013-4.

Turchin, P., Hoyer, D., Bennett, J., Basava, K., … & Whitehouse, H. (2020). The Equinox2020 Seshat Data Release. *Cliodynamics: The Journal of Quantitative History and Cultural Evolution*. https://doi.org/10.21237/C7clio11148620.

Works in preparation

Basava, K. (revisions submitted). "War". In L. G. Boothroyd, L. H. Lidborg, Y. Birch, R. Kapitany, S. Lew-Levy, and B. Rawlings (eds.), *Evolution, Culture and Human Behaviour Textbook*. Cambridge: Open Book Publishers. [invited chapter for the European Human Behaviour and Evolution Association]

Other writing

Basava, K. (2021). Cultural phylogenetics of afterlife beliefs. *Nature Human Behavior: Behind the Paper.* https://socialsciences.nature.com/posts/cultural-phylogenetics-of-afterlife-beliefs.

Presentations

Basava, K. "The evolution of cultural diversity and extinction risk in cetaceans." Cultural Evolution Society, University Mohammed VI Polytechnic, Rabat, May 2026.

Basava, K. & Roman-Palacios, C. "The Animal Culture Database (ACDB): A Pilot database of animal cultures." Evolution Meeting, Athens, GA, June 2025.

Basava, K. "A cross-cultural analysis of social complexity and the taking of human body parts as trophies during war." Cultural Evolution Society, Aarhus University, Denmark, September 2022.

Basava, K. "A phylogenetic analysis of headhunting practices and political complexity in Austronesian societies." Evolution Meeting, virtual, June 2022.

Birk Sørensen, A. L.; Basava, K.; Vanhersecke, Z.; George, N. "Does behavioral repertoire predict brain size in coleoid cephalopods? A test of the cultural brain hypothesis". Cephalopod International Advisory Council, Sesimbra, April 2022.

Basava, K. "A cross-cultural study of social complexity and indiscriminate violence in war." European Human Behaviour and Evolution Association, Max Planck Institute for Evolutionary Anthropology, April 2022.

Teaching and mentoring

01-05/2026 Co-Instructor, ANTH170C1: Human Variation in the Modern World, University of Arizona

- Developed materials and lectured for undergraduate introductory biological anthropology class (~40 students)

2025-2026 Center for the Integration of Research, Teaching and Learning Postdoc Pathways Program
- Taking course and participating in weekly cohort discussions on evidence-based undergraduate teaching
- Participated in workshop on neuro-affirmative teaching practices

2025 Mentor to Paige Cherry, undergraduate student in Information Science
- Trained an undergraduate research assistant to code data from the literature on animal behavior and culture; met weekly to provide research and career guidance

Specialized training and courses

05-06/2024 Library Carpentry (Python, regular expressions, tidy data, UNIX shell), University of Arizona

09-12/2024 Applied Natural Language Processing, University of Arizona

01/2024 Causal Inference Course for Health and Social Scientists, Leeds University

02/2023 Data Management with SQL for Ecologists, Data Carpentry

07/2022 Sydney Phylogenetics Workshop, Molecular Ecology, Evolution, and Phylogenetics Laboratory

01/2021 Macroevolution and Phylogenies, Transmitting Science

04-07/2020 *Statistical Rethinking: A Bayesian Course with Examples in R and Stan*, Reproducible Research Oxford (RROx) book club

Other activities

06/2026 Wild Animal Welfare Summit, New York University
- Participated in summit on capacities of wild animals, human interactions, and priorities for wild animal welfare as a field; led discussion on wild animal culture and welfare

06-07/2023 Diverse Intelligences Summer Institute
- Fellow at interdisciplinary program with seminars and collaborative projects on comparative cognition, biological and cultural evolution, and collective intelligence

2020-2023 Cultural Evolution Server
- Assisted with organization of cross-disciplinary, virtual journal club holding regular discussions and providing mutual support for early career cultural evolution researchers

05/2019 Chez-Pinaud Jonzac, PACEA, Université Bordeaux, France
- Participated in excavation of Middle Paleolithic site of reindeer skeletal remains associated with Quina Mousterian lithics; assisted with screening, sorting, and labeling specimens